

DD Daniel Davies

Marking with Confidence: Calibrating to a Rubric

A short staff module on judging Level 4 work against a rubric, and writing feedback that matches the mark

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Welcome: How to use this module

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Welcome

Welcome to this short staff module on marking with confidence.

The module is for lecturers and markers, especially those teaching business or a related subject. It is written in plain English and takes about 12 to 15 minutes. You can pause and come back.

You will mark three short sample answers against a simple rubric. The samples, the company, and the figures were written for this module. They are not real student work.

By the end, you will be able to:

- explain why a written rubric still needs a short calibration on sample work
- judge three invented Level 4 briefings against a generic rubric, and place each in a defensible band
- give a short rationale that points to evidence in the script
- write feedback that matches the band, names a criterion, and offers a next step

This module was designed by Daniel P Davies, Associate Lecturer at Liverpool John Moores University. He teaches business, and his doctoral research looks at AI-supported feedback and assessment for Level 4 international business students.

A rubric is necessary, but it is not enough on its own. Shared judgement grows when we practise on the same samples, and talk about the evidence in the work.

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How to use this module

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Step 1

Step 1: Read the task and the rubric

Lesson 1 sets out a generic Level 4 briefing, a short company pack, and a three-criterion rubric. These are teaching examples only.

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Step 2

Step 2: Judge the three samples yourself

In Lesson 2 you will read three invented answers and place each in a band. Try the question before you open the rationale.

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Step 3

Step 3: Compare your judgement with the moderation note

Each rationale points to evidence in the script. The aim is not a single "perfect" number, but a defensible band and a comment that matches it.

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Step 4

Step 4: Follow your own procedures

This module uses generic examples. Your own marking policy, second-marking rules, and feedback template still apply.

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Summary

A note about the examples

Northbridge Cycles, the town of Elmford, the company pack, the figures, the three sample answers, and the rubric are all generic examples only. They were written for teaching. They are not from a real module, and they do not use real student work or real marks.

Your own assignments will look different. The method should still transfer: read the task and the pack, mark to the published criteria, and make the evidence in the script visible in both the band and the comment.

CONTINUE

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Lesson 1: The task, the rubric, and why we calibrate

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A generic Level 4 briefing

Here is the task the three sample answers were written for. It is a generic example only.

Generic example task:

Write a 200-word management briefing. Recommend whether Northbridge Cycles, a fictional UK bicycle retailer, should add a click-and-collect service in its Elmford store. Use only the company pack. You may recommend a full launch, a limited trial, or no change, but you must justify the recommendation.

Generic example pack (invented for teaching):

- A short customer survey in the Elmford store found that 31 out of 50 customers (62%) said they would use click-and-collect if it were offered.

- The 50 responses were collected in one store, on one Saturday.

- A nearby competitor already offers click-and-collect.

- The Elmford store has limited back-of-house space.

- Staff would need half a day of training before a launch.

- In this teaching pack, the average in-store basket is £48, and the average online order is £29. These figures are invented.

The figures above are not real market data. They exist so that you and your colleagues are judging the same evidence.

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THE THREE CRITERIA	70 AND ABOVE	60 TO 69	50 TO 59	
1. Recommendation and justification: is there a clear recommendation, and is it justified in relation to the task? 2. Use of evidence from the pack: does the briefing use relevant pack evidence, and does it notice any limits in that evidence? 3. Structure and professional communication: can a reader find the recommendation, the evidence, and any limitation quickly, in clear professional English?				

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THE THREE CRITERIA	70 AND ABOVE	60 TO 69	50 TO 59	
The recommendation is clear and well judged. Evidence from the pack is used with care, including at least one relevant limitation. The briefing is concise, well organised, and easy to act on.				

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THE THREE CRITERIA	70 AND ABOVE	60 TO 69	50 TO 59	

The recommendation is clear and mostly justified. Relevant pack evidence is used, and there is some attention to a limitation or a risk, even if that discussion could go further. The briefing is clearly structured and professionally written.

THE THREE CRITERIA	70 AND ABOVE	60 TO 69	50 TO 59	

The task is addressed and a recommendation is made. Some pack evidence is used, but it may be partial, or a limitation in the evidence may be missed. The structure is usually clear enough, but the justification may overreach the evidence.

THE THREE CRITERIA	70 AND ABOVE	60 TO 69	50 TO 59

The task is attempted and a recommendation is present, so the work is not a complete miss. Evidence is thin or very general, and analysis is limited. The writing may be uneven, but a reader can still see what is being recommended.

THE THREE CRITERIA	70 AND ABOVE	60 TO 69	50 TO 59	

The task is missed, or there is no usable recommendation, or the briefing does not use the pack in

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any meaningful way.

Mark the work against these criteria, not against a sense of the student, and not against a preferred share of each band.

Equity

Bloxham, Hughes, and Adie (2016) describe equity as consistency and fairness for students. In plain terms, this includes giving markers a chance to develop a shared understanding of the standard, and then judging work against that agreed standard.

Justification

Justification is about confidence in the decision, and the ability to explain it (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016). A defensible comment points to evidence in the script, not only to a feeling that the work "felt like a 2:1".

Accountability

Accountability, in their account, is about showing that an agreed process has been followed (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016). This module does not tell you what your own process must be. It does ask you to make your reasoning visible.

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Community building —

Community building is the work of calibrating judgements and building shared interpretations of criteria and standards (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016). A short workshop on sample scripts, before a large marking load, is one way to do that.

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1. Design

Check the task and the rubric

Before students write, check that the task and the rubric ask for the same performance. If the rubric marks a skill the brief never invites, later calibration will be harder.

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2. Calibration

Practise on samples first

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Compare judgements of the same sample scripts, and justify those judgements against the criteria (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016, Table 1). This is the work you will practise in Lesson 2.

3. Judgements

Mark to the agreed standard

Once marking is under way, keep returning to the criteria and to the evidence in each script. If two markers disagree, discuss the evidence rather than only splitting the difference.

4. Feedback check

Make sure the comment matches the band

A fair process also includes the written comment. If the band is a basic pass, the feedback should not read as if the work were excellent throughout.

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Continue to the samples

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Lesson 2: Three sample answers

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Judge these three briefings

The next block contains three complete sample answers. All three were written for this module. They are generic examples only. They are not real student work.

Read each one against the generic rubric and the pack in Lesson 1. Then choose a band. After each question, read the feedback, and then compare it with the moderation notes later in this lesson.

A useful habit, supported by research on how markers actually work, is to notice your first whole-script impression, then check it against the written criteria. Bloxham, Boyd, and Orr (2011) found that assessors often made holistic rather than analytical judgements, and that written criteria were often used after the event to refine, check, or justify that decision. Calibration on shared samples makes that checking step visible, and helps a team talk about the same evidence.

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SAMPLE A (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY) | **SAMPLE B (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY)** | **SAMPLE C (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY)**

Northbridge Cycles should add click-and-collect in Elmford as soon as possible. Modern customers want convenience, and most shops are doing this now, so the company will look out of date if it

waits. People like to order online and pick things up, and this will make the store busy and more successful. There may be some issues in the shop, but these can be managed, and staff can learn as they go. Click-and-collect is a good idea and will help the brand. I think the company should go ahead and advertise it widely so that everyone in the town knows about it. This will make Northbridge Cycles more popular than other shops.

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SAMPLE A (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY) | SAMPLE B (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY) | SAMPLE C (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY)

This briefing recommends that Northbridge Cycles should roll out click-and-collect fully in the Elmford store. The customer survey found that 62% of customers said they would use the service, which shows strong demand. A nearby competitor already offers click-and-collect, so the company may lose customers if it does not keep up. There is limited back-of-house space, which is a problem, but the demand figure is high enough to justify a full launch. Staff would need half a day of training, which is a short time. For these reasons, the store should introduce the service for all suitable products as soon as training is complete.

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SAMPLE A (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY) | SAMPLE B (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY) | SAMPLE C (GENERIC EXAMPLE ONLY)

Northbridge Cycles should run a time-limited trial of click-and-collect in the Elmford store, not a full launch. The survey figure of 31 out of 50 customers (62%) is a useful signal of interest, but the sample is small and was collected on one Saturday in one store, so it should not be treated as proof of steady demand. A nearby competitor already offers the service, which is a reason to test it rather than to ignore it. Limited back-of-house space, and the need for a half-day of staff training, also argue against an immediate full roll-out. A trial in a narrow product range would test demand and operations before the store gives up more space. The higher average in-store basket (£48) compared with the average online order (£29) is another reason to watch whether click-and-collect supports, or weakens, store spending.

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Using only the generic example rubric and pack in this module, which band is the best fit for Sample A?

- 70 and above.
- 60 to 69.
- 50 to 59.
- 40 to 49.
- Below 40.

SUBMIT

Using only the generic example rubric and pack in this module, which band is the best fit for Sample B?

- 70 and above.
- 60 to 69.

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- 50 to 59.
- 40 to 49.
- Below 40.

SUBMIT

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Using only the generic example rubric and pack in this module, which band is the best fit for Sample C?

- 70 and above.
- 60 to 69.
- 50 to 59.
- 40 to 49.
- Below 40.

SUBMIT

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SAMPLE A, 40 TO 49	SAMPLE B, 50 TO 59	SAMPLE C, 60 TO 69	IF YOUR BAND DIFFERED

Rationale: There is a recommendation, so the task is attempted. There is almost no pack evidence: no survey figure, no mention of the small sample, no space or training point, and no basket comparison. "Some issues" is not analysis. On this rubric, that is a basic pass.
Matched comment you could use: "You do make a recommendation, which means the task has been attempted. For a stronger mark, use evidence from the pack. For example, include the survey figure, and say what is limited about that evidence, before you decide between a full launch and a trial."

SAMPLE A, 40 TO 49	SAMPLE B, 50 TO 59	SAMPLE C, 60 TO 69	IF YOUR BAND DIFFERED

Rationale: Several pack points are present, and the structure is clear. The main problem is overreach. The 62% figure is treated as strong demand, but the pack also says the sample is 50 customers on one Saturday. The briefing notes limited space and then still advises a full roll-out. That is a mid-band profile: evidence is used, but the justification runs ahead of it.
Matched comment you could use: "You use relevant pack points, including the 62% figure, the competitor, and the space limit, and your structure is clear. The next step is to weigh the limits in the evidence. The survey is small and from one Saturday, so it cannot, on its own, justify a full launch, especially where storage space is already tight. Consider whether a trial would better match the evidence you already have."

SAMPLE A, 40 TO 49	SAMPLE B, 50 TO 59	SAMPLE C, 60 TO 69	IF YOUR BAND DIFFERED

Rationale: The recommendation (a time-limited trial) fits the evidence. The briefing uses the 31 out of 50 figure and names the limits of that sample. It also brings in space, training, competitor

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pressure, and the invented basket-size contrast. It is professionally written. It stops short of 70 and above in this teaching example because the implications of the basket-size point, and of how the trial would be judged, could still be sharper.
Matched comment you could use: "Your recommendation of a time-limited trial is clear and is well matched to the pack, including the small, one-day sample. You also weigh operations and competitor pressure, which strengthens the justification. To push this further, make the trial criteria more explicit: for example, say what the store would look for, in demand and in basket size, before deciding on a full roll-out."

SAMPLE A, 40 TO 49	SAMPLE B, 50 TO 59	SAMPLE C, 60 TO 69	IF YOUR BAND DIFFERED

A one-band difference can happen, especially on a boundary. If you were a band out, look back at the descriptor and at one piece of evidence in the script. In a live team, that is the conversation worth having. Avoid only averaging two marks, which can pull a standard towards the middle without settling what the criteria mean (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016).

Continue to moderation principles

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Lesson 4 of 6

Lesson 3: Moderation and consistent feedback

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Five habits for consistent marking

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Step 1

Calibrate on samples before the full load

Compare judgements of the same scripts, and justify them against the criteria (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016). Do this before, not only after, a large set of marking.

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Step 2

Return to the published criteria

A first whole-script impression is common (Bloxham, Boyd, & Orr, 2011). The professional step is to check that impression against the rubric, and to be willing to revise it.

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Step 3

Point to evidence in the script

If two markers disagree, talk about what is on the page. Splitting the difference can look like agreement without settling the standard (Bloxham, Hughes, & Adie, 2016).

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Step 4

Do not invent a new criterion

If the rubric does not mark handwriting, font, or a favourite theory the brief never asked for, do not let those become the hidden standard.

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Step 5

Match the comment to the band

Name the criterion, point to a feature of the work, and give a next step. A mid-band script should not receive a comment that reads as if the work were excellent throughout.

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Summary

Matches the band

Band: 50 to 59. "Some pack evidence, but the launch overreaches. Try a trial."

Band: 60 to 69. "Trial well matched to the survey limits. Say how it is judged."

Band: 40 to 49. "You make a recommendation. Next, use pack evidence."

Does not match

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Band: 40 to 49. "An outstanding briefing, with excellent analysis throughout."

Band: 60 to 69. "This work fails, because I prefer a different company example."

Band: 50 to 59. "Perfect in every respect. Nothing to improve."

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Two markers disagree on Sample B. One has 48, the other has 58. What is the most useful next step in this teaching example?

- Award 53, by splitting the difference, and write no rationale.
- Return to the rubric and the script, and discuss whether the justification overreaches the pack evidence.
- Give the higher mark automatically, so that the student is not disappointed.
- Ignore the rubric, because experienced markers should rely

only on instinct.

SUBMIT

Continue to the quiz

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Lesson 5 of 6

Check your learning

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This short quiz has four questions. It checks the ideas you have just practised. You can retry it. You need 3 out of 4 to pass. After the quiz, there is a short closing note and a further-reading list.

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Question

01/04

According to Bloxham, Hughes, and Adie (2016), which of the following is a purpose of moderation?

- To replace a rubric with a mark scheme based only on spelling.
- Community building: calibrating judgements and building a shared interpretation of criteria and standards.
- To make sure every script is placed in the same band, whatever the quality of the work.
- To publish students' marks to the whole class.

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Question

02/04

Why does this module ask you to mark sample scripts, rather than only to read the rubric?

- ◯ Because sample scripts can replace a rubric altogether.
- ◯ Because written criteria are necessary, but markers still need practice at applying them to work, and at checking a first impression against the evidence.
- ◯ Because all Level 4 work looks the same, so one sample is enough forever.
- ◯ Because students should never be shown a rubric.

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Question

03/04

A colleague awards Sample A a mark in the 40 to 49 band, and writes: "An outstanding briefing, with excellent analysis throughout." What is the main problem?

- ◯ There is no problem, because encouragement is always more important than accuracy.
- ◯ The comment is too short.
- ◯ The comment does not match the band, and it does not describe the work.
- ◯ The colleague should have failed the script for being short.

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Question

04/04

In this teaching example, what is the best reason for placing Sample C in the 60 to 69 band rather than in 50 to 59?

- Because longer briefings must receive higher marks.
- Because the trial recommendation is matched to relevant pack evidence, including a limitation in the survey, and the briefing is clearly organised.
- Because Sample C mentions a competitor, and that single point is enough for 60 to 69.
- Because the marker liked the tone, even though the pack was ignored.

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Lesson 6 of 6

One next step

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Take one habit back to your marking

If you have a marking load coming up, try this, with your own procedures in mind:

1. Agree the task and the rubric with colleagues before you start.

2. Mark two or three sample scripts (anonymised, or invented teaching samples if live work cannot be shared yet).

3. Talk about the evidence in the work, not only about a preferred number.

4. Write one comment that a student could match to the band: name a criterion, point to the script, and give a next step.

You do not need to redesign a whole assessment system this afternoon. One calibrated set, and one matched comment, is a solid start.

A fair mark is one you can explain from the criteria and the work.

Further reading

These are the sources cited in this module. All were opened and checked when the script was written.

- Bloxham, S., Boyd, P., & Orr, S. (2011). Mark my words: the role of assessment criteria in UK higher education grading practices. Studies in Higher Education, 36(6), 655–670. https://doi.org/10.1080/03075071003777716

- Bloxham, S., Hughes, C., & Adie, L. (2016). What's the point of moderation? A discussion of the purposes achieved through contemporary moderation practices. Assessment & Evaluation in Higher Education, 41(4), 638–653. https://doi.org/10.1080/02602938.2015.1039932

You do not need to read these papers in order to complete the activities. Your own marking procedures still apply.

Thank you for working through this module.

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